A Priori Knowledge of the World: Kant's Question and Three Computed Answers

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Abstract

Kant asked how synthetic a priori knowledge is possible: knowledge which says something about the world and yet owes nothing to observation. His own answer, that the knower supplies the form of experience, is not believed any more, and his leading example was refuted when physical space turned out not to be Euclidean. The question survived the answer. I give three examples, of rising difficulty, in which a quantity belonging to the world is obtained without any measurement of it: the circumference of the circle $x^2 + y^2 = 1$; the drag and lift of a body in incompressible slightly viscous flow, from the shape of the body alone; and the configuration of a molecule, from its atoms alone.

The criterion which makes all three a priori is not that no physical process occurred but that *the object was never interrogated* — no circle was drawn, no wing placed in a tunnel, no water in the room. And the answer to Kant's question is then available in a form he could not have reached: such knowledge is *latent information made explicit by labour*. The content was in the input, so nothing was created; but latent is not available, and the only route from implicit to explicit is a chain of steps. This both deflates the mystery and relocates it, because the question is no longer whether the knowledge is possible but at what rate the implicit becomes explicit and whether the rate can be certified. In the first example the answer is exact, in the second and third it is a computed number with a bound, and the thing which separates them is dissipation. Finally, none of the three is a priori all the way down: each rests on a small empirically won law. The a priori is not groundless but *leveraged* — observation buys the law once, and computation spends it indefinitely.

1 Kant's question

The *Critique of Pure Reason* is organised around a question which is easy to state and hard to dismiss. Some judgements are analytic: the predicate is already contained in the subject, as in *bachelors are unmarried*. These are certain and they are empty, telling us about our words rather than about the world. Other judgements are synthetic a posteriori: they add something, and they are bought with experience, as in *this rod is one metre long*. Between the two Kant placed a third class, synthetic a priori: judgements which add something about the world and are nonetheless known without consulting it. He held that mathematics is of this kind, and the principles of pure natural science with it, and he asked how that is possible.

His answer was the one thing in the *Critique* everybody remembers. It is possible, he said, because the form of experience is contributed by the knower rather than found in the object. Space and time are forms of sensible intuition; substance and causality are forms of the

understanding. We can know in advance what must hold of any possible object of experience because we supply the mould into which experience is poured. Objects conform to our mode of cognition, not the reverse.

That answer is not believed now, and Kant's own leading instance of it failed: he held the geometry of physical space to be Euclidean, knowably so a priori, and it is not. The question nonetheless did not go away, and in the two and a half centuries since it was asked the stock of examples has grown in a direction Kant could not have anticipated. The a priori knowledge now arrives out of a computation. I give three instances in order of rising difficulty and then ask what they have in common.

2 First example: the circle

Define a curve by $x^2 + y^2 = 1$. Its circumference is $2\pi = 6.283185\ldots$, and one may have as many further digits as one is willing to pay for. Nothing was measured. No circle was drawn, no string laid along a rim, no instrument consulted. A quantity belonging to a figure in space was obtained from a definition.

Two features of this are worth recording, because both recur in the harder examples.

The definition does not contain the digits. It is a short formula. The number it determines is transcendental — Lindemann settled that in 1882 — so there is no finite expression for it in rationals and no amount of staring at $x^2 + y^2 = 1$ will produce 3.14159. The digits are obtained by *construction*: Archimedes inscribed and circumscribed polygons and squeezed the value between 223/71 and 22/7, and every later method is likewise a procedure which must be run. So the knowledge is a priori and it is also work. *A priori does not mean free.* It names the source of the knowledge, not its cost.

The knowledge is conditional. The claim is not that any round thing in the world has circumference 2π times its radius. It is that *if* the shape is the one defined, *then* the circumference is that. The condition is not a weakening. It is what makes the statement exact, and it is the form in which the a priori survived the collapse of Kant's version of it (§8).

3 Second example: drag and lift from the shape of the body

Aerodynamics was empirical in its foundations. The drag coefficient of a sphere, a cylinder, an aerofoil is a tabulated quantity, and the tables came from wind tunnels. An engineer sizing a structure looks up a number which somebody else measured on a model of something like it.

The claim of the computational programme is that this detour through measurement is unnecessary. Solve the Euler equations for incompressible flow with slight viscosity, with a slip or small friction condition at the body, and the drag and the lift come out of the shape of the body alone. No turbulence model fitted to data, no measured coefficient, no boundary layer resolved, no circulation inserted by hand to make a wing lift. The input is a shape. The output is a force.

What had to be cleared out of the way first was d'Alembert's paradox, which stood for two centuries: the inviscid incompressible equations admit potential flow, and potential flow has zero drag, so the equations appeared to contradict the most elementary observation about fluids. The resolution is that potential flow is unstable. It is a solution and it is not the one which occurs; what occurs is a turbulent wake whose formation is itself computable, and which carries the drag.

The honest form of the claim is already in the record of the programme, and it is stranger than the claim itself: mean drag and lift converge to a few per cent on meshes on which the velocity field does not converge and never will. The *output* is knowable while the *solution* is not. I return to this in §9, because it is the clearest sign that what is being computed is not the fluid but a functional of it.

The two features of §2 reappear. The knowledge is a priori and it is expensive: a mesh, a solver, a stopping criterion, and a number which arrives with a bound rather than exactly. And it is conditional: given this shape, that force.

4 Third example: the configuration of a molecule from its atoms

Give the nuclear charges and how many electrons there are. Nothing else. No measured bond lengths, no force constants taken from spectroscopy, no basis set contracted against molecular data, no exchange–correlation functional calibrated on a training set of molecules whose answers were known in advance. Then minimise the energy of a collection of non-overlapping charge densities, one per electron, interacting by Coulomb's law with each pair counted once. The configuration of the molecule is what comes out.

From the record: for water, the equilibrium O–H bond comes out at $1.814\,a_0$, on the measured value, and the H–O–H angle at 101.6° against the measured 104.5°. The lone pair is not put in by hand — the sector of the oxygen valence pointing away from both hydrogens is simply where the energy puts it. Four free densities about a single kernel, seeded lopsidedly, relax into the tetrahedral basin rather than the square one, which is methane's 109.47° arrangement arrived at rather than assumed.

What does *not* come out a priori is the absolute energy. The programme's own verdict on itself is that the geometry is right and the energies are wrong: errors cancel in differences taken within one composition and do not cancel across compositions. This is the most interesting of the three cases rather than the weakest, and §9 is about why.

5 What makes the knowledge a priori

An objection arrives immediately. A computer is a physical object; a computation is a physical process, taking time, dissipating heat, occasionally giving the wrong answer because a transistor was struck by a cosmic ray. If the number came out of a physical process, in what sense was it obtained without observation?

The criterion is not whether some physical process occurred. It is whether *the object was interrogated*. A spectrometer interrogates the molecule: light goes in, the molecule responds, and the response makes the number, so the molecule is a cause of the result. A simulation of

water consults no water. The silicon is physical and it stands in no causal relation whatever to any sample of H_2O; one could run it in a universe containing no water at all and get the same digits. In the three examples no circle was drawn, no wing was placed in a tunnel, and there was no water in the room.

This is a sharper criterion than "independent of experience", which is vague enough to have absorbed two centuries of argument. It also has a clean consequence: the a priori character of a result is a fact about its causal provenance, and can therefore be settled by asking what was in the room.

6 How it is possible

The deflationary half of the answer should be stated first, because it is true. In each case the answer was already in the input. The definition of the circle determines 2π. The Euler equations together with the shape determine the drag. Coulomb's law together with the non-overlap condition determines the geometry. The computation creates no information about the world; it transfers information from the law to the prediction.

The other half is equally true and it is the whole point. **Latent is not available.** Nobody can read the H–O–H angle off Coulomb's law by inspection, and nobody ever read π off $x^2+y^2 = 1$. The content is implicit, and the only route from implicit to explicit is a chain of steps. This is the argument made at length elsewhere about why solving is not empty: the equation posits exactly as axioms do, its solution is implied but unavailable, and a chain of steps — Newton's method as readily as a proof — constructs what was not there before. Nobody says that a computed solution of a differential equation is empty on the ground that the equation already determined it.

So the answer to Kant's question is:

> A priori knowledge of the world is *latent information made explicit by labour*.

The possibility was never the mysterious part. What was missing from the old debate was any account of the labour, and that is exactly what was unavailable before there were machines to do it, because the labour in the interesting cases is far beyond hand calculation.

Once it is put this way, Kant's question changes shape rather than getting answered on its own terms. He asked whether such knowledge is possible. The computational era answers yes, routinely, industrially, and replaces the question with a better one: *at what rate does the implicit become explicit, and can the rate be certified?* For π the cost is known in advance and the digits are exact. For drag the cost is a mesh and the certificate is a bound obtained by duality against a computed adjoint solution. For a molecular geometry the certificate is a mesh ladder and a step ladder, and a difference below the drift of the iteration carries no information. The modulus is the content — which is the same conclusion one reaches coming at this from the side of constructive existence, and it is reassuring that two routes arrive at it.

7 The empirical kernel, and leverage

None of the three examples is a priori all the way down, and the accounting should be kept honest.

That $x^2 + y^2 = 1$ describes anything in the world is not a priori. Euler's equations were not deduced from anything; they were found, over two centuries, by people attending to how fluids behave, and conservation of mass and momentum together with incompressibility is empirical input. RealQM takes Coulomb's law, the charge of the electron, the charges of the nuclei and the number of electrons, and every one of those is a measured fact about this world.

So the structure of all three cases is the same, and it is worth stating as a single sentence: **a small empirically won law, together with a specification, yields unlimited a priori consequence.** The a priori is not groundless. It is *leveraged*. A finite empirical investment is repaid indefinitely by computation — a few constants and a variational principle, and from them every molecule there is.

This is a better account than either party to the old dispute managed. The rationalist was wrong that the knowledge comes from nowhere; it comes from a law, and the law was observed. The empiricist was wrong that every new fact about the world must be bought with a new observation; most of them need no observation at all, because they were already entailed. What actually happens is that observation buys the law once and computation spends it forever.

8 Where Kant was wrong, and why it leaves the examples standing

Kant's own flagship case failed. He held Euclidean geometry to be synthetic a priori and true of physical space. Gauss, Bolyai and Lobachevsky produced consistent alternatives, Riemann gave the general framework in 1854, and general relativity made the matter empirical in 1915: the geometry of space is contingent, and which one holds is settled by observation. This is usually taken to be the end of the project.

It leaves the three examples untouched, because none of them repeats the mistake. None asserts a geometry of the world unconditionally. Each says: given this specification, that consequence. The circle example does not claim that physical space is Euclidean; it claims that the curve so defined has that circumference. The flow example does not claim that air is an incompressible continuum; it claims that a body of this shape in such a fluid feels that force. RealQM does not claim that Coulomb's law is a necessary truth; it claims that charge obeying it, so constrained, arranges itself so.

The lesson of the refutation of Kant is precisely the move from the categorical to the conditional, and in conditional form the a priori is not merely defensible but ordinary. It is what every computation does.

9 Form before magnitude

The three examples do not behave alike, and the difference is instructive rather than embarrassing. Set them out as a ladder.

	closed form	what is certified	limit
circle	yes	nothing needed; exact	—
flow	no	the output, by duality	solution does not converge
molecule	no	differences at fixed composition	absolute magnitudes

What rises down the table is irreducibility of the computation. And what the second and third share, which the first does not, is *dissipation*. The flow sends energy to scales no mesh resolves, and the drag survives that only because it is a mean value. The molecular configuration is reached by a relaxation which approaches equilibrium asymptotically and never arrives, so that every quantity read off it is read off at a finite time and carries the drift of the iteration. Where there is dissipation there is no closed form, and the a priori must then be bought with a modulus rather than stated in a formula.

The pattern in what RealQM gets right and wrong is then sharp. It delivers *form* a priori — which site, which branch, which geometry, which symmetry, tetrahedral rather than square, where the lone pair points — and not *magnitude*. The structural results do not depend on the energies being right, which is why they survive the admission that the energies are not.

There is an odd echo of Kant in this, who also held that what the a priori supplies is form. I do not want to press a resemblance into an argument, and the sense of "form" is not his. But it is worth noticing that when a programme sets out to compute the world from its law and nothing else, the first thing to come out is shape.

10 What it changes

If drag follows from shape and molecular geometry follows from charge, then the wind tunnel and the diffractometer change their role. They stop being where the number comes from and become where the theory is tested. That is not a demotion — a theory with no check against the world is worth nothing, and the three examples are credible only because their outputs have been compared with measurement. But it reverses the direction of supply, and that reversal is the practical content of the whole argument.

It also places the frontier for automation exactly where the companion articles place it. The labour by which the implicit becomes explicit is machine work now, and increasingly good machine work; systems have begun to produce research-level proofs and they write and run solvers. The empirical kernel is not machine work — the law, the formulation, the decision about what the object is — and not because the technology is young. There is nothing to derive a formulation from, so no chain of steps produces one.

Kant asked how we can know anything about the world without looking at it. The answer, two and a half centuries on, is that we look once, carefully, and then compute.